MASTER'S THESIS

Investors' Emotional Intelligence and the Gender Funding Gap: An Experimental Study

submitted by

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Theory and Hypotheses

The Gender Funding Gap

Despite growing awareness of and advocacy for gender equality in entrepreneurship, significant disparities persist in startup financing between male and female founders (Geiger, 2020). The gender funding gap describes systematic differences in venture funding, whereby women founders receive less capital and face lower likelihood of securing funding than male founders (Geiger, 2020; Hellmann et al., 2025). Despite progress over the past two decades, the gender funding gap remains substantial (Brush et al., 2018). In 2024, 87% of German startup funding went to all-male founding teams, while all-female teams received only around 1% (Ernst & Young, 2025). This mirrors a broader global pattern in which all-male teams captured 83.6% of venture capital, mixed-gender teams 14% and all-female teams 2.3% in 2025 (Founders Forum Group, 2025). The disparity cannot be explained by venture quality alone, as women-led startups achieve comparable exit outcomes and equal or higher valuations once funded (Brush et al., 2018). Nevertheless, women founders face greater barriers when seeking external finance (Geiger, 2020) and are further less inclined to pursue capital to begin with (Kwapisz & Hechavarría, 2018). Recent meta-analytic and systematic reviews suggest that the gender funding gap arises from the interplay of investor biases, entrepreneurs' characteristics, structural market conditions and broader contextual influences (Koziol et al., 2025; Ross & Shin, 2024).

A central characteristic of the gender funding gap is that women and men founders are not evenly distributed across industries. Women founders are concentrated in less capital-intensive sectors such as consumer goods, retail, health and care services, whereas men are overrepresented in sectors such as fintech, information technology (IT), hardware and construction (Aernoudt & San José, 2020; Sperber & Linder, 2023; Yacus et al., 2019). The latter sectors attract the largest share of venture capital, while the sectors in which women cluster attract considerably less (Aernoudt & San José, 2020; Yacus et al., 2019). This uneven distribution matters because it means that founder gender and industry are deeply entangled in practice (ibid.). This means that differences in funding between male and female founders may partly reflect the industries they operate in rather than founder gender alone (ibid.). Explanations of the gender funding gap should therefore account for both founder gender and the industry in which they operate (ibid.).

Industries are not only economic categories but carry a gender-typing of their own (Yacus et al., 2019). A male-dominated industry is one in which men make up the clear majority of founders and in which the prevailing image of the successful entrepreneur is masculine (ibid.). Conversely, a female-dominated industry is one in which women predominate, and the prevailing image is feminine (ibid.). These definitions are adopted throughout the present study. Sperber & Linder (2023) demonstrate that IT is widely viewed as a masculine field because men continue to dominate it. As a result, the industry has become closely associated with a masculine image of entrepreneurship (ibid.). These associations, tied to field itself, shape how ventures are perceived even before the specific founder is evaluated (ibid.).

The masculine coding of these sectors aligns with investors' expectations of an ambitious, high-growth and scalable venture (Sperber & Linder, 2023). Consequently, ventures in male-dominated industries often attract greater investor interest and are perceived as more fundable than ventures in female-dominated industries (Guzman & Kacperczyk, 2019; Sperber & Linder, 2023). Industry context may shape funding decisions independently of founder gender. Before examining how founder gender shapes investment decisions, it is therefore necessary to establish whether investors systematically favour male-dominated industries independent of who leads the venture. Since male-dominated industries are associated with high-growth ventures, they attract greater investor attention and capital than female-dominated industries (Aernoudt & San José, 2020; Guzman & Kacperczyk, 2019). We therefore expect ventures in male-dominated industries to receive more funding than ventures in female-dominated industries. Thus, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 1: *Investors allocate more capital to startups in male-dominated industries than to startups in female-dominated industries*

Role Congruity Theory

Industry preferences provide an important starting point, but they do not tell us whether women and men are evaluated in the same way within those industries. To understand this pattern, we turn to role congruity theory. According to the theory, prejudice arises when characteristics associated with a social group are perceived as inconsistent with the requirements of a particular role (Eagly & Karau, 2002). This mismatch, referred to as role congruity bias, leads to less favourable evaluations of individuals who are perceived as a poor fit for a particular role (ibid.). Research distinguishes between two clusters of gender stereotypes, communality and agency. Women are stereotypically associated with communal traits such as warmth, kindness and nurturance, whereas men are more strongly associated with agentic traits such as aggression, ambition, dominance and independence (Brescoll, 2016; Eagly & Karau, 2002; Heilman & Caleo, 2018; Koenig et al., 2011). Applied to entrepreneurship, investors carry an implicit image of the successful founder, and that image is masculine (Gupta et al., 2009). Entrepreneurs are often described as independent, autonomous, aggressive and courageous, traits more commonly associated with men than with women (ibid.). As a result, men are often seen as a more natural fit for the founder role, while women are more likely to be seen as less suited to it (Eagly & Karau, 2002; Gupta et al., 2009; Koenig et al., 2011).

This mismatch operates in two ways (Eagly & Karau, 2002). Women may be perceived as a poorer fit for entrepreneurship because the communal characteristics associated with women are often seen as less consistent with the entrepreneurial role (Eagly & Karau, 2002; Gupta et al., 2009; Koenig et al., 2011). At the same time, women who do display agentic qualities may be penalized for violating gender expectations, a reaction often referred to as backlash (Rudman & Glick, 1999; Rudman et al., 2012). This creates a double standard in which the same venture signal is interpreted differently depending on the founder's gender (Eddleston et al., 2016). Eddleston et al. (2016) show that investors reward the characteristics of men and women differently, often to the disadvantage of women. Strong performance by women tends to be rewarded less because it is less consistent with common expectations of successful entrepreneurs (ibid.). Yang et al. (2020) demonstrate that this pattern extends beyond pitch evaluations and carries real financial consequences. Women who send signals that do not align with gender expectations are not merely rewarded less but can be actively penalized relative to sending no signal at all (ibid.). This pattern does not apply to men in the same way (ibid.). The findings suggest that the double standard becomes particularly visible when women depart from communal expectations (Eagly & Karau, 2002; Yang et al., 2020).

Importantly, investors do not evaluate founders in isolation. Industries carry gendered expectations and founders are judged against them (Tonoyan & Strohmeyer, 2021). A founder who matches the gender-typing of the industry is congruent, while a founder who does not is incongruent (ibid.). Role congruity theory suggests that founders are evaluated more favourably when their gender matches the gendered expectations associated with an industry (Eagly & Karau, 2002; Tonoyan & Strohmeyer, 2021). Tonoyan & Strohmeyer (2021) formalise this into a conceptual model in which the evaluation of the founder depends on the match between the founder's gender and the gender-typing of the industry. Consequently, a woman founder may be evaluated differently in a male-dominated than in a female-dominated industry (ibid.). Evaluations therefore do not depend on founder gender alone, but on the perceived match between the founder and their startup (ibid.). A similar pattern emerges in pitch evaluations (Balachandra et al., 2019). Investor decisions appear to be shaped less by the founder's sex per se than by behaviours associated with gender stereotypes and perceptions of competence (ibid.). Consistent with role congruity theory, the resulting disadvantage reflects perceptions of fit and the entrepreneurial role rather than direct antipathy against women (Balachandra et al., 2019; Eagly & Karau, 2002). The relevance of perceived fit extends beyond traditional funding settings. Women achieve better crowdfunding outcomes when their ventures are socially oriented, as the social focus aligns more closely with common expectations associated with women founders (Anglin et al., 2022). Importantly, the advantages are not linked to being a woman per se, but to the fit between the founder and their startup (ibid.). This is consistent with the broader argument that perceived fit plays an important role in shaping investors' evaluations (Anglin et al., 2022; Eagly & Karau, 2002).

Combining the industry effect with the role congruity theory leads to a clear prediction about two key pairings. Male founders in male-dominated industries benefit from an alignment between founder gender, industry context and the masculine image of an entrepreneur. As a result, these ventures are likely to appear particularly attractive to investors. A female founder in a female-dominated industry is also congruent, as founder gender and industry context are aligned. However, female-dominated industries attract less capital, and female founders do not match the masculine image associated with entrepreneurship. Consequently, this combination does not benefit from the same advantages as the masculine-congruent combination. We therefore expect male founders in male-dominated industries to attract more investment female founders in female-dominated industries. Thus, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 2: *Male founders in male-dominated industries receive more investment than female founders in female-dominated industries*

Emotional Intelligence and Role Congruity Bias

Emotional intelligence (EI) is the ability to accurately perceive, appraise and express emotions, to understand emotion and emotional knowledge and to regulate emotions to promote emotional and intellectual growth (Mayer & Salovey, 1997). EI therefore lies at the intersection of emotion and cognition, both of which are fundamentally intertwined in human information processing, reasoning and decision-making (Mayer et al., 2008; Phelps, 2006). Research generally distinguishes between two dominant perspectives. The ability-based approach defines EI as a set of emotional abilities, whereas the trait-based approach treats EI as a personality trait (Furnham & Petrides, 2003; Mayer & Salovey, 1997). The present study adopts the ability-based approach because it provides a stronger basis for explaining how emotional capabilities shape judgments and decision-making (Mayer & Salovey, 1997).

The importance of EI becomes particularly relevant because investment decisions are not guided by formal evaluation criteria alone. Individual perceptions, feelings and cognitive shortcuts often shape evaluations in ways that investors do not fully recognize (Johansson et al., 2021). This is particularly evident in the context of gender bias. Kanze et al. (2018) demonstrate that male founders were more likely to receive promotion-oriented questions about aspirations and potential gains, whereas female founders were often asked prevention-oriented questions that focus on risk mitigation and loss avoidance. These findings are particularly important because investors are typically unaware of these differences in their evaluations (ibid.). The influence of unconscious processes extends beyond questioning patterns. Schreiber et al. (2025) found that male investors evaluated attractive female founders more favourably and perceived them as more competent. Importantly, investors remained unaware of these influences and viewed their decisions as objective and rational (ibid.). Together, this suggests that investment decisions are shaped by processes that operate beyond conscious reasoning (Johansson et al., 2021; Schreiber et al., 2025).

The Stereotype Content Model (SCM) helps explain why emotions play a central role in gender bias (Fiske et al., 2002). The model suggests that stereotypes influence behaviour through the emotions they evoke (Cuddy et al., 2007; Fiske et al., 2002). Female founders, for example, are often perceived as highly competent but less warm, which can evoke emotions such as envy (Eckes, 2002). These emotions are more closely related to discriminatory behaviour than stereotype content itself (Cuddy et al., 2007; Fiske et al., 2002). As a result, investment decisions may be influenced not only by perceptions of the founder, but further by the emotions these perceptions evoke.

If bias is delivered through emotion, then the capacity to perceive and interpret emotion should determine how far the bias is expressed. EI becomes particularly relevant in this context. Yip & Côté (2013) provide direct evidence that emotion-understanding ability, a core dimension of EI, shapes financial decision-making. Individuals with higher ability recognized that their emotional reactions were unrelated to the decision at hand therefore did not let it influence their judgment (ibid.). Individuals with lower ability misattributed the emotion to the decision itself and allowed it to bias their judgment (ibid.). Seo & Barrett (2007) reach a similar conclusion. Investors made better decisions when they were able to accurately identify and understand their emotions. However, experiencing emotions more strongly was only beneficial when investors could correctly interpret those feelings and prevent them from biasing their judgment (ibid.). Applied to the present context, investors may experience a negative reaction when a female founder appears inconsistent with the entrepreneurial role. What matters is whether investors recognize that this reaction is driven by gender stereotypes rather than by the quality of the venture itself.

Direct evidence links EI to lower levels of prejudice (Makwana et al., 2021). Makwana et al., (2021) show that individuals with stronger emotion-management abilities express less prejudice toward outgroups. Conversely, lower emotional abilities are associated with higher levels of prejudice and more negative evaluations of outgroup members (Makwana et al., 2021; van Hiel et al., 2019). This mechanism can be explained as follows: Individuals with high EI, particularly strong emotion management abilities, are better able to regulate negative emotions (such as anxiety, threat or disgust) evoked by outgroups (Makwana et al., 2021). This increases empathy and understanding of others, which promotes more tolerant attitudes toward outgroup members (ibid.). Individuals with lower EI, in contrast, may be more likely to rely on these emotions when forming judgments (ibid.). Van Hiel et al. (2019) further link lower emotional abilities to a greater reliance on stereotypes and categorical thinking, ultimately leading to higher levels of prejudice. Higher EI should therefore be associated with less biased decisions, since individuals with stronger emotional abilities are better able to recognise emotional reactions without allowing them to influence their judgment. In the present context, an investor with higher EI should be better able to separate emotional reactions from venture quality itself. An investor with lower EI may be more likely to allow these reactions to shape investment decisions.

This logic helps explain the role of EI in the present model. EI is expected to act as a moderator of congruity bias, influencing how strongly congruity bias affects investment decisions. As a result, the congruity preferences described in the first two hypotheses should not be equally strong across all investors. Instead, they should be strongest among investors who are less able to understand and regulate their emotional reactions. Investors with higher EI should therefore be more likely to recognize that feelings of fit or misfit do not necessarily reflect the quality of the venture. Investors with lower EI may be more likely to allow these emotions to influence their decisions. When feelings of fit or misfit are not recognized, they may influence how investors evaluate a startup’s potential. As a result, congruity bias can therefore influence funding decisions and ultimately contribute to differences in capital allocation.

The difference in capital allocation should be most visible when comparing two congruent pairings. Male founders in male-dominated industries represent the strongest match between founder gender, industry context and common expectations of entrepreneurs. As outlined in Hypothesis 2, this pairing should create a stronger sense of fit than the female founder and female dominated industry pairing. Among investors with lower EI, these perceptions of fit are more likely to influence evaluation of the venture and ultimately, funding decision. Among investors with higher EI, perceptions of fit should play a smaller role because these investors are better able to recognize and regulate their emotional reactions. As a result, the difference in capital allocated to masculine-congruent and feminine-congruent startups should be larger among investors with lower EI. Thus, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 3: *Among investors lower in emotional intelligence, masculine-congruent startups receive higher investment than feminine-congruent startups*

Emotional Intelligence and the Gender of Investors

The extent to which congruity bias shapes funding outcomes depends not only on individual investors but also on the composition of the investor pool. The venture capital industry remains overwhelmingly male-dominated, with women being substantially underrepresented among those making investment decisions (Brush et al., 2018; Ewens & Townsend, 2020; Gatewood et al., 2009). This is particularly relevant because EI differs systematically between men and women.

Joseph & Newman (2010) show that women tend to score higher than men on ability-based EI. This difference is already evident in emotion recognition, where women consistently outperform men in recognizing emotional expressions (Thompson & Voyer, 2014). Evidence from large-sample studies further suggests that this advantage extends across the different branches of EI and across age groups (Cabello et al., 2016). The strongest gender differences appear to be in the ability to perceive and understand emotions (Cabello et al., 2016; Joseph & Newman, 2010). Overall, the evidence suggests a robust gender difference in EI, with women tending to score higher than men.

The findings have important implications for the present argument. Venture capital investors are predominantly men (Brush et al., 2018; Ewens & Townsend, 2020; Gatewood et al., 2009), and men tend to score lower on EI than women (Cabello et al., 2016; Gatewood et al., 2009; Thompson & Voyer, 2014). As a result, the investor pool may disproportionately consist of individuals who are more likely to be influenced by congruity bias. This suggests that EI may contribute to the gender funding gap not only at the individual level but also through the characteristics of the investor pool. In the present study, this argument can be tested through participant gender. Accordingly, we expect male participants to score lower on EI than female participants. Thus, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 4: *Male participants score lower on emotional intelligence than female participants*

Investment Experience as a Boundary Condition

The discussion so far has focused on EI as one factor that may reduce congruity bias. However, EI may not be the only factor that helps investors make less biased decisions. Experience may offer a second route to reducing congruity bias. Kahneman & Klein (2009) describe expert intuition as the ability to recognize patterns developed through experience. Experts therefore rely on what they have learned from previous situations rather than on their initial reactions (ibid.). As experience increases, experts become better able to distinguish relevant information from irrelevant influences (ibid.). Management research reaches a similar conclusion. Dane & Pratt (2007) argue that experience helps experts develop an intuitive understanding of their domain. This allows them to recognize meaningful patterns rather than relying on simple cues or immediate emotional reactions (ibid.). Experience thus offers an alternative way of limiting the influence of emotional reactions on judgments (Dane & Pratt, 2007; Kahneman & Klein, 2009).

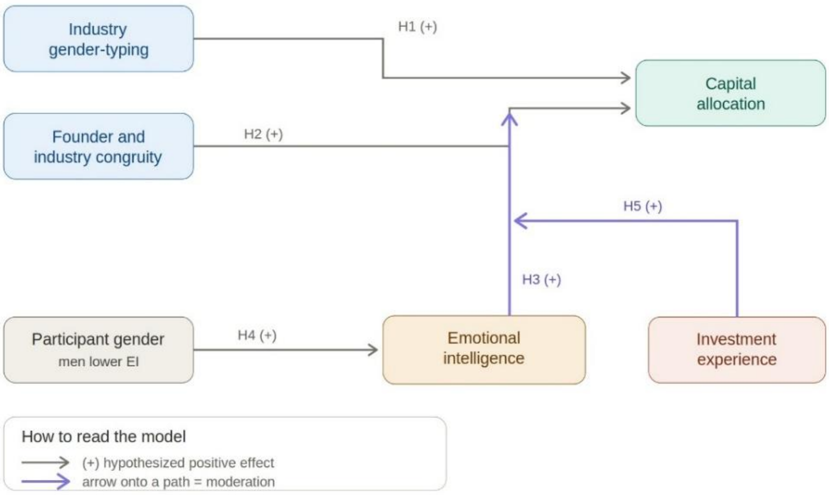
This experience does not need to be specific to investing. The ability to put setbacks into perspective can develop through broader life and professional experience as well (Kahneman & Klein, 2009). However, experience is usually most useful within the domain in which it was acquired (Dane & Pratt, 2007). In the funding context, this makes investment experience particularly relevant (ibid.). Over time, experienced investors learn from the ventures they evaluate and develop a sense of which signals point to success (Zacharakis & Shepherd, 2001). As a result, experienced investors rely less on their initial reaction and more on signals they have learned to associate with success (Dane & Pratt, 2007; Zacharakis & Shepherd, 2001). Thus, experience gives investors something to rely on when emotions might otherwise shape their judgment (Zacharakis & Shepherd, 2001). Nevertheless, experienced investors are not free from bias and may still be overconfident in their decisions (ibid.).

The two resources, EI and experience, could therefore serve a similar function in investment decisions. The previous chapters argued that congruity bias is strongest among investors low in EI because they are less able to recognize and correct feelings of fit or misfit. Experience may provide an alternative basis for investment decisions. Investors who are less able to regulate their emotions can still fall back on learned patterns from previous investment decisions. Investment experience therefore moderates the relationship between EI and congruity bias. Among investors with low EI, experience provides an alternative basis for judgment and reduces the gap in capital allocated to masculine-congruent and feminine-congruent startups. Thus, we hypothesize:

Hypothesis 5: *Among investors lower in emotional intelligence without prior investment experience, masculine-congruent startups receiver higher investment than feminine-congruent startups*

Figure 1

Conceptual Model of Investors Emotional Intelligence and Role Congruity Bias



The model brings the five hypotheses together. Startups in male-dominated industries attract more capital than startups in female-dominated industries (Hypothesis 1). Within this context, male founders in male-dominated industries receive more investment than female founders in female-dominated industries (Hypothesis 2). This difference in capital allocation is not uniform across investors but is strongest among those lower in EI (Hypothesis 3). EI acts as a moderator of congruity bias, determining how strongly the founder-industry pairing translates into a difference in capital allocation. Men score lower on EI than women (Hypothesis 4). Since the investor pool is predominantly male, the pool may contain more individuals prone to congruity bias. Investment experience acts as a conditional moderator of the relationship between EI and congruity bias. It does not weaken congruity bias for all investors. Only among investors lower in EI, greater investment experience is associated with a smaller difference in capital allocation to masculine-congruent relative to feminine-congruent startups (Hypothesis 5).

Method

Design and procedure

The study was a laboratory experiment administered in Qualtrics and conducted in German. It employed a mixed design with two factors. Industry was varied within subjects: every participant evaluated two startup pitches, one operating in a male-dominated industry (construction technology) and one operating in a female-dominated industry (corporate wellness). Founder gender was varied between subjects in three conditions: an all-female founding team, an all-male founding team and a mixed-gender founding team. The mixed-gender condition served as the control condition because the founding team included both women and men. Within each condition, the gender composition of the founding team was held constant across both pitches, so that a participant assigned to the female-founder condition evaluated both startups with female founders. This provided a 2 (industry: male-dominated versus female-dominated, within subjects) × 3 (founder gender: all- female, all-male and mixed teams, between subjects) design. The order in which the two pitches were presented was counterbalanced, producing six experimental groups in total.

The experiment was conducted in the WU Labs at the Vienna University of Economics and Business. Participants were seated at randomised computer stations and completed the study at their own pace. After providing informed consent, participants read an explanation of the incentive structure and answered three comprehension-check questions to verify that they understood the payout mechanism. They then proceeded to read the two startup pitches one after the other. After reading both pitches, participants made their investment decisions for both startups. They then rated the perceived probability of success and perceived riskiness of each startup, completed the manipulation checks, rated each founding team on twelve trait adjectives from the Stereotype Content Model (SCM) and completed the Wong and Law Emotional Intelligence Scale (WLEIS). The survey concluded with two items on risk tolerance and a set of demographic questions. At the end of the session, a randomised draw determined whether each startup was successful and participants received their payout in cash. The median completion time was approximately 20 minutes. Data were collected in May 2026.

Incentive Structure

The study used a real-money incentive mechanism designed to elicit sincere investment decisions. Each participant received a guaranteed show-up fee of €7. For each of the two startup pitches, participants were given an investment budget of €3, corresponding to a fictitious capital of €300,000. Participants could invest €0, €100,000 (1€), €200,000 (2€) or €300,000 (€3) per pitch. Any portion of the budget that was not invested was placed into a savings account, of which 50% was paid out at the end of the session. If a startup was successful, the invested amount was doubled. If it was not successful, the invested amount was lost. The success of each startup was determined independently by a random draw at the end of the session. Participants received no information about the probability of success beforehand, mirroring the uncertainty characteristics of a real investment decision. Total payouts ranged from €7 to €19. Participants received their payout in cash at the end of the session.

Participants

Participants were recruited through the WU Labs recruitment system. Eligibility required proficiency in German. The initial dataset contained 230 recorded responses. Two manipulation checks were applied sequentially. Participants had to correctly recall the industries of the two startups as well as the gender composition of the founding teams. Those who answered incorrectly or who indicated that they could not remember were excluded. Applying both checks reduces the sample from 230 to 187 responses.

The final sample comprised 100 women (53.5%), 84 men (44.9%), two non-binary participants (1.1%) and one participant who preferred not to disclose their gender (0.5%). The mean age was 23.4 years (SD = 4.8, range 17-57). The sample was dominated by German (36.4%) and Austrian (26.7%) nationals. The remainder comprised a range of nationalities, most notably Ukrainian (5.3%), Bulgarian (4.8%) and Russian (4.3%). Most participants held a high school diploma (58.1%) or a bachelor's degree (34.1%). Consistent with this, the majority were currently pursuing a bachelor's (59.8%) or a master's degree (27.4%), most commonly in Business Administration or Management. About 60% reported prior experience with financial investments (such as stocks, funds or cryptocurrency), whereas only 12% had previously founded or actively participated in founding a company.

Stimuli: The Startup Pitches

All participants read two startup pitches, one in a male-dominated industry and one in a female-dominated industry. Within each condition, the gender of the founding team was held constant across both pitches. One pitch presented SiteVision, a construction technology startup that offered an AI-driven platform for automated construction-site documentation via drone. The second pitch presented BalanceUp, a corporate wellness startup that used AI to provide well-being and mental-health services for employees.

The two pitches were designed to be equivalent on characteristics known to influence investment decisions. Both ventures requested the same amount of funding, presented founding teams of the same size with complementary expertise, reported identical validation results and described identical growth prospects. Holding these features constant isolates the effects of founder gender and industry context.

Experimental manipulation

The between-subjects manipulation concerned the gender of the founding teams. Participants saw a founding team consisting either of four women, four men or an equal mix of two women and two men. The mixed-gender condition served as the control condition. The presence of both male and female founders weakens the gender signal that drives congruity bias in other conditions. Within each startup pitch, the text was identical across the three founder-gender conditions except for the founders' first names and the corresponding pronouns.

Founder gender varied between participants, while both pitches within a condition carried the same gender composition. Holding team compositions constant across the two pitches prevents direct comparison between male and female founding teams. The order in which the two pitches were presented was counterbalanced across participants within each founder-gender condition.

Measures

Scales originally developed in English were translated and adapted into German.

Investment decision. The dependent variable was the amount of how much each participant chose to invest in each startup. For each pitch, participants selected one of the four options: €0, €100,000, €200,000 or €300,000. The two investment decisions were presented on a single page after both pitches were read, with the question explicitly naming each startup to avoid order confusion.

Perceived probability of success. For each startup, participants rated the statement "How likely do you think it is that this startup will be successful?" on a seven-point scale (1 = very unlikely to 7 = very likely). This item was adapted by Zacharakis & Shepherd (2001).

Perceived investment risk. For each startup, participants rated the riskiness of the investment on three seven-point semantic differential items (high-low, extreme-minimal, very risky-not risky). The items were adapted from Forlani & Mullins (2000). Higher scores indicate lower perceived risk.

Stereotype content. Participants rated the founding team of each startup on twelve trait adjectives adopted from the Stereotype Content Model (Fiske et al., 2002), using five-point scales (1 = not at all to 5 = very much). Six items measured competence (competent, confident, capable, efficient, intelligent and skilful) and six items measured warmth (friendly, well-intentioned, trustworthy, warm, good-natured and sincere). The ratings were collected separately for each founding team, with the item order randomised within participant.

Emotional intelligence. Emotional intelligence was measured with the sixteen-item Wong and Law Emotional Intelligence Scale (Wong & Law, 2002), using seven-point scales. The scale comprises four subscales of four items each: self-emotion appraisal (SEA), others' emotion appraisal (OEA), use of emotion (UOE) and regulation of emotion (ROE). Sample items from each dimension, respectively, include "I have a good understanding of my own emotions", "I am a good observer of others' emotions", "I always set goals for myself and then try my best to achieve them" and "I am quite capable of controlling my own emotions". In the survey, all sixteen items were presented in a single numbered sequence without subscale labels and the item order was randomised within participants.

Risk aversion. Risk aversion was measured with two items from Dohmen et al. (2011). The first item asked participants to rate their general willingness to take risks on an eleven-point scale (0 = not at all willing to take risks to 10 = very willing to take risks). The second item asked participants to rate their willingness to take financial risks on the same scale.

Manipulation checks. Two manipulation checks were included after the investment decision. The first asked participants to recall the industries in which the two startups operated, using a multiple-response format with four industry options and an "I don't remember" option. The second asked participants to recall the gender composition of the founding teams, using a single-response format with three options (all-female, all-male, mixed team) and an “I don’t remember” option. Participants who failed either check were excluded from the analysis.

Demographics. Participants reported their gender, age, nationality, highest completed educational qualification, the degree they were currently pursuing, their field of study, whether they were enrolled at the Vienna University of Economics and Business, whether they had prior experience with financial investments and lastly, whether they had previously founded or participated in founding a company.

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